Example: Wheat and Soybean. It also occurs in few perennials also. Example: *Agave* and Bamboo.

ii. **Top senescence**: It occurs in aerial parts of plants. It is common in perennials, underground and root system remains viable. Example: Banana and *Gladiolus*.

iii. **Deciduous senescence**: It is common in deciduous plants and occurs only in leaves of plants, bulk of the stem and root system remains alive. Example: Elm and Maple.

iv. **Progressive senescence**: This kind of senescence is gradual. First it occurs in old leaves followed by new leaves then stem and finally root system. It is common in annuals (Figure 15.23).

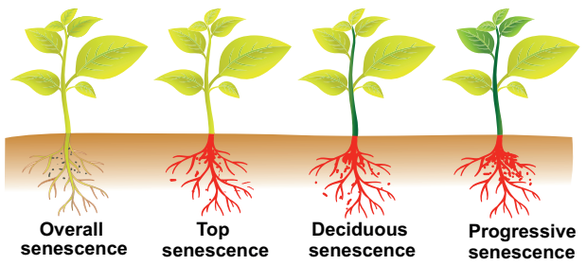


Figure 15.23: Different types of senescence in plants

2. Physiology of Senescence

- Cells undergo changes in structure.
- Vacuole of the cell acts as lysosome and secretes hydrolytic enzymes.
- The starch content is decreased in the cells.
- Photosynthesis is reduced due to loss of chlorophyll accompanied by synthesis and accumulation of anthocyanin pigments, therefore the leaf becomes red.
- There is a marked decrease in protein content in the senescing organ.
- RNA content of the leaf particularly rRNA level is decreased in the cells due to increased activity of the enzyme RNAase.
- DNA molecules in senescencing leaves degenerate by the increased activity of enzyme DNAase.

3. Factors affecting Senescence:

- ABA and ethylene accelerate senescence while auxin and cytokinin retard senescence.
- Nitrogen deficiency increases senescence whereas nitrogen supply retards senescence.
- High temperature accelerates senescence but low temperature retards senescence.
- Senescence is rapid in dark than in light.
- Water stress leads to accumulation of ABA leading to senescence.

4. Programmed cell death (PCD)

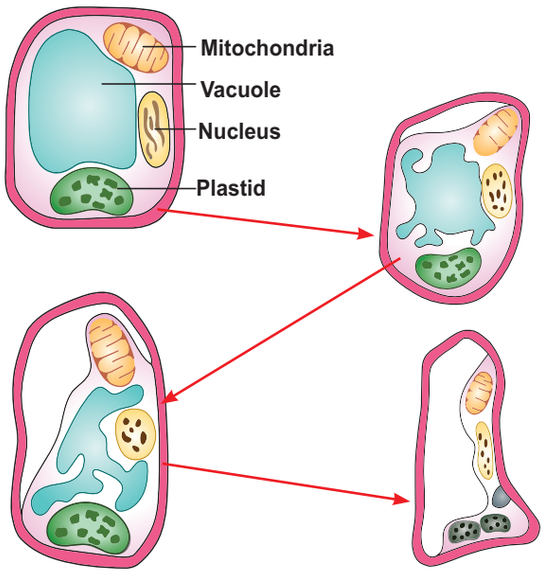


Figure 15.24: Programmed cell death

Senescence is controlled by plants own genetic programme and death of the plant or plant part consequent to senescence is called **Programmed Cell Death**. In short senescence of an individual cell is called **PCD**. The proteolytic enzymes involving PCD in plants are **phytaspases** and in animals are **caspases**. The nutrients and other substrates from senescing cells and tissues are remobilized and reallocated to other parts of the plant that survives. The protoplasts of developing xylem vessels and tracheids die and disappear at maturity to make them functionally efficient to conduct water for transport. In aquatic plants, aerenchyma is normally formed in different parts of the plant such as roots and stems which encloses large air spaces that are created through PCD. In the development of unisexual flowers, male and female flowers are present in earlier stages, but only one of these two completes its development while other aborts through PCD (Figure 15.24).

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